DOUBLE TROUBLE

CHIRAG SHETTY, 24
Mumbai

SATWIKSAIRAJ RANKIREDDY, 21
Shuttlers, Amalapuram, AP

India's badminton challenge finally got a formidable partnership going in 2016 when then coach Tan Kim Her asked Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy to team up. He knew their similar height and attacking styles would pay off. It didn't take them long to set aside linguistic barriers–Chirag is from Mumbai while Satwiksairaj is from Andhra Pradesh–and demonstrate that theirs is a pairing that can win titles and medals.

The year 2018 saw them win a gold (mixed team) and a silver (men's doubles) at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Not only are the two the first Indian men's doubles team to be ranked in the top 10 but also the first to win a Super 500 title (2019 Thailand Open) and be recognised with the Arjuna Award (2020). With age on their side and the Asian Games, Commonwealth Games and Paris Olympics not too far away, the shuttlers will be India's best bet for a medal alongside P.V. Sindhu. ■

–Suhani Singh

ON THE BUTTON Satwik is a big fan of PUBG while Chirag is steeped in Netflix. Both also love Japanese food



COURTESY HOCKEY INDIA

"Siami was very young when she broke into the senior squad. She is extremely talented, skillful and courageous"

RANI,
Captain, Indian Women's Hockey Team

LALREMSAIMI, 21

Hockey player, Kolasib, Mizoram

Dynamic Dribbler

No girl from Mizoram had made the cut for India's senior hockey team until Lalremsiami, then only 17, stormed onto the turf and wowed with her speed and skills. An integral part of India's silver medal-winning team at the 2018 Buenos Aires Youth Olympics, scoring nine goals, she also stood out as a dynamic forward at the Asian Games and Asian Champions Trophy where she won the tournament's U-21 rising star award.

Siami, as she is fondly known by her teammates, says her heart was set on hockey the moment she first held a stick. "I was always fascinated by how one can manoeuvre the ball with it," she says. Recently appointed a hockey coach by Mizoram's Department of Sports and Youth Services, she is keen to popularise the sport. "There are definitely more girls taking up hockey in Mizoram now. We even have a girl who has made it to the national junior team," she says with barely disguised pride. ■

–Suhani Singh

HEROINE WORSHIP The first player from Mizoram in India's women's hockey team, Lalremsaimi's idol is Rani Rampal, the current captain